



SAFE

Washing your hands well and cleaning surfaces with soap helps remove harmful germs. This stops bacteria or viruses from getting into your food. This is one of the best ways to keep food safe and prevent food poisoning.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics



NOT SAFE

Leaving meat like hot dogs in warm weather for more than 2 hours lets bacteria grow fast. This food is in the "danger zone" temperature where germs can make you sick. Eating it can cause food poisoning.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics



IT DEPENDS

Pickles are acidic foods, which usually stop dangerous bacteria from growing. However, if the pickles were not made with enough vinegar or the jar was contaminated, they might not be safe. Keep pickles refrigerated after opening to be safe.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics



SAFE

Maya followed a tested recipe and used a boiling water canner because fruits are acidic enough for that method. Using new lids, filling jars hot, and processing for the full time kills harmful bacteria.

Testing the seals makes sure no air or bacteria got in. This makes the peaches safe to store and eat later.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits



NOT SAFE

Using old or dented lids can prevent jars from sealing properly, allowing bacteria or molds to grow. Processing for less time can leave harmful microorganisms alive. Unsealed jars may spoil quickly and could cause food poisoning if eaten.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits



IT DEPENDS

Asian pears are low-acid fruits and need added acid (like lemon juice) during canning to make the environment safe for boiling water canning. If lemon juice was forgotten, bacteria like *Clostridium botulinum* could survive and grow, making the pears unsafe if stored unrefrigerated. If stored cold (in the fridge), the risk is much lower, but it's best to follow tested recipes and add acid for room-temperature storage safety.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits



SAFE

When canning tomato salsa, it's important to use a recipe tested for safety that adds enough acid, like lemon juice, to stop bacteria from growing. Processing the jars for the right time in a boiling water canner kills harmful germs. Proper sealing and storage keeps your salsa safe to eat.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning



NOT SAFE

Tomatoes from frost-killed or overripe fruit can lose acidity, making them unsafe to can without extra acid added. Without enough acid, bacteria like *Clostridium botulinum* can grow during storage and cause serious illness.

Source: PNW 300 Canning tomatoes and tomato products



IT DEPENDS

If a jar doesn't seal, the canned salsa can spoil or let bacteria grow. But if you keep it cold in the fridge and use it quickly, it can be safe. Don't store unsealed jars at room temperature because harmful germs could grow.

Source: PNW 300 Canning tomatoes and tomato products



SAFE

Green beans are low-acid foods, so they must be canned in a pressure canner to reach high enough temperatures to kill harmful bacteria like *Clostridium botulinum*. Using tested recipes and following exact pressure and time ensures safety. Properly sealed jars stored in a cool, dark place remain safe to eat.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game



NOT SAFE

Cooked meat is a low-acid food that can harbor botulism bacteria unless canned at high temperature in a pressure canner. Boiling water bath canners don't reach a high enough temperature, so contamination and toxin risk remain, even if jars appear sealed and food looks normal.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game



IT DEPENDS

Garlic in oil is a low-acid food that can grow botulism bacteria if not stored properly. Keeping it refrigerated helps, but homemade garlic oils are safe for only about 3 weeks unless they're acidified. After that, the risk of botulism toxin increases, so safety depends on how long and how cold it's stored.

Source: PNW 450 Canning smoked fish at home



SAFE

Using vinegar with 5% acidity is very important for safety because it prevents harmful bacteria from growing. Sticking closely to the recipe's vinegar amount ensures the pickles will be safe to eat. Keeping pickles refrigerated after sealing helps stop bacteria from growing.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables



NOT SAFE

Lime used for pickling must be food-grade and not garden or lumberyard lime, which can be toxic. Also, not rinsing cucumbers after soaking in lime can leave harmful chemicals that are unsafe to eat.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables



IT DEPENDS

Fermented pickles need to be kept under the brine and covered to prevent mold and insects. Some bubbles are normal from fermentation, but mold can be unsafe. Safety depends on whether the mold is just on the surface and if you remove it or if the fermentation was done correctly.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables



SAFE

Emma used a proven recipe with enough sugar and acid, boiled the jam to kill harmful germs, sealed the jars tightly, and stored them properly. This keeps the jam safe to eat for a long time.

Source: SP 50-765 Low sugar fruit spreads



NOT SAFE

Liam didn't add enough acid or cook the jam long enough, so it might not be acidic enough to stop bad bacteria from growing. This can make the jam spoil or even cause food poisoning.

Source: SP 50-765 Low sugar fruit spreads



IT DEPENDS

Freezer jam is safe if kept frozen, since freezing stops bacteria. But if kept in the fridge for a week, it might spoil because it's not cooked like boiled jam. It's important to follow the recipe's storage instructions.

Source: SP 50-763 Uncooked freezer jams



SAFE

Cooling leftover foods quickly before freezing helps stop bacteria from growing. Keeping the freezer at 0°F or below keeps food safe and preserves quality for months. Food kept at this temperature is safe to eat even after long storage.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables



NOT SAFE

If a can is bulging or the lid is broken, bacteria might have grown inside even if it was frozen. Eating food from damaged cans can cause food poisoning, so it should be thrown away.

Source: SP 50-695 Safety of canned food that freezes



IT DEPENDS

Thawing meat in the fridge is safe if you cook or freeze it within a couple of days. After 3 days, the meat might start to spoil and could make you sick. Always check the meat for smell or color changes before cooking.

Source: PNW 296 Freezing convenience foods that you've prepared at home



SAFE

If fruit is properly dried so it has very little moisture left, and stored in a cool, dark place that prevents moisture and light, it stays safe to eat. This stops mold and bacteria from growing.

Source: PNW 397 Drying fruits and vegetables



NOT SAFE

Small metal smokers often can't reach high enough temperatures to kill harmful bacteria. If fish isn't cooked to 160°F after smoking, it might still have dangerous germs that can make you sick.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home



IT DEPENDS

Jerky made safely requires the meat to be heated to 160°F before or right after drying to kill germs. If the meat wasn't heated properly, it might still contain harmful bacteria. So, safety depends on whether the meat reached that temperature.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely